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TRANSNATIONAL DISCOURSES AND CIRCUITS OF QUEER KNOWLEDGE IN INDONESIA

Evelyn Blackwood

Global lesbian and gay liberation discourse contains within it progressive narratives of the development of modern sexual identities. Activist lesbian discourse in particular holds the expectation that modern lesbian subjects will express a self-consciousness or awareness of sexual identity as “lesbians” and “women.” The intersections of global, activist discourses and individual subjectivities, however, are much more complex and layered than such a narrative suggests. In Padang, West Sumatra, tombois and their girlfriends, who identify themselves as masculine and feminine, respectively, access global circuits of queer knowledge and see themselves as part of a global community, but maintain subject positions that are distinct from the identities promoted and encouraged by activist lesbian organizations in Indonesia. In this article I examine the ways activists and individuals in Padang selectively appropriate circuits of queer knowledge as they make sense of their own subjectivities and negotiate their places in the “lesbian” world. I offer insights into the asymmetries of reception and the consequent multiplicity of desires and subjectivities as a way to challenge fixed identity categories and incorporate the diversity of queer subjectivities within a “global gay” ecumene.

The queer discourses that I interrogate here are those promoted by international lesbian and gay, or more recently LGBT, organizations, which are oriented to Western queer knowledge and the queer political movements of the United States or Europe, and queer discourses that circulate in the global ecumene among activist networks and identity-based communities and organizations. These discourses are not separate and distinct but intersect in many intriguing and contradictory ways to produce a transnational queer discourse that is multiple and disparate, shaped

by asymmetries of race, class, and gender, and reconstituted into particular subjectivities that do not fit neatly into Western-defined identity categories.¹ Arnaldo Cruz-Malavé and Martin F. Manalansan IV note that global queer discourses seem to follow “a unidirectional path” in which the West or Western cultures are seen as the origin of lesbian and gay consciousness and identity.² Paola Bacchetta argues that the Western neocolonial version of queer discourse tends toward an effacement of sexualities that do not have the appearance of modern same-sex identity emblematic of the lesbian and gay liberation movement of Europe and North America.³ The traditional/modern dichotomy of Western thought perpetuates the assumption that individuals who do not reflect “modern” sexual identities are somehow marginalized, left behind, or in need of education to become fully liberated modern queers.⁴ Western queer discourse to a certain extent relies on this dichotomy to create a developmental teleology that situates other sexualities as premodern, that is, not yet lesbian or gay, while placing Western sexualities at the pinnacle of modern, autonomous sexuality.⁵ Similarly, as Bacchetta notes, the “from-Stonewall-diffusion-fantasy” situates the origin and foundation of the modern queer movement at a particularly U.S. American moment in time.⁶ In this universalizing turn, Western queer discourses bypass the historicity and specificity of gendered and sexual subjects within and outside the “West,” relegating their stories to the margins of queer movements.

In addition, the ubiquitous *LGBT* of Western gay discourse provides a fixed set of categories and the assurance of familiar definitions in which, if slippage within categories is recognized, slippage across them is not. In these more expansive versions of lesbian and gay, the *T* in *LGBT* works to resolve the messy categories of identity politics, creating a distinct boundary between lesbian/gay and transgender.⁷ *T* refers to and incorporates masculine females and transgender men, who are thereby not considered women or lesbians (in the sense of butch lesbians, although transgender individuals express a range of sexual orientations, including lesbian). *LGBT* circulates globally, particularly in the activities and Web sites of international sexual rights organizations and conferences.⁸ The use of the term *LGBT* by these organizations in their literature and on their Web sites is not necessarily meant to promote or claim particular identities. In regionally focused pages of these Web sites, more-specific or “local” terms may be used, as well as such phrases as “gender and sexual diversity.”⁹ In fact the use of *LGBT* may be more related to efforts to create a broad appeal across diverse international communities.¹⁰ Nevertheless, Western labels have a certain cachet that offers users a “modern” or urban sensibility and connection to a larger international community.¹¹ This cachet works to promote *LGBT* as an originary ideal equated with

fixed and stable identities within which all sexual diversity can be slotted. These identities are variously taken up by activists and nonactivists alike in their efforts to secure a stake in the global LGBT community.

The fixity of identities promoted by such terms as *LGBT* needs to be reconsidered in light of the tombois, lesbian men, and other masculine females whose lives blur the boundaries of “lesbian” and “transgender.”¹² Evident throughout Asia in both cities and rural areas are masculine females whose own identities are firmly located in localized gender regimes as well as in global signifiers apparent in the proliferating forms of the English term *tomboy* that they use to identify themselves. *TB*, *tom*, and *tomboi* are some of the variations used in Hong Kong, Thailand, and Indonesia, respectively (other terms are also used in each location). Their women partners see themselves variously as normative women, who do not fit into a category of nonnormative sexuality, or as bisexual or lesbian because of their attraction to masculine lesbians.¹³ These individuals, like their activist peers, are influenced by global feminist and queer processes as well as by localized processes that are negotiated to construct the particular forms of sexuality and gender evident in Asia today. Although seemingly divergent, these gendered and sexual subjectivities are part of and responsive to global queer discourse.

My use of *queer* in this article stems from my understanding of the complexity of sexuality discourses and knowledges that circulate and proliferate globally under such signifiers as lesbian, gay, LGBT, same-sex sexuality, bisexuality, and transgender, as well as words in national languages adopted from or in reference to those terms. Part of the purpose of this article is to examine the processes by which labels are established, appropriated, and claimed. The use of *queer* may reify or reproduce a Western way of understanding a current profusion of non-normative gender and sexual subjectivities in the United States, but I think the value, and also the problem, in using *queer* lies in its nonspecificity. As I see it, *queer* refers not to one way of being but to a range of transgressive possibilities that encompass and surpass *LGBT*, thus opening up the global gay ecumene to multiple and disparate subjectivities.¹⁴ Although *queer* is not used (yet) in Indonesia, it is available to Indonesians via the Internet and at the queer international conferences they attend.¹⁵ In a transnational world there are no borders or neat boundaries that contain particular words. Nor, as Ruth Vanita points out, are words or meanings ever fixed; all terms are approximations and never fit well across or even within borders.¹⁶ I use *queer* in this article when I refer to multiple forms of gender and sexual subjectivities, discourses, or knowledges; I do not use it in reference to specific subjectivities in Indonesia. I employ Indonesian words, such as *lesbi* or *tomboi*, to refer to particular subject positions. These two words

are cognates of the English words *lesbian* and *tomboy* but do not share the same meanings and resonances as their English counterparts. And, as I demonstrate in this article, even those terms are contested. Following the same reasoning, I use the terms *transgender* and *masculine females* to refer to the range of embodied genders from masculine women to females who identify as men to transmen. The terms do not mean that these individuals are men or even that they constitute a third gender, as any such assignment of gender would ignore the fluidity of gender in many of these individuals' lives.

In an effort to destabilize the borders of lesbian/gay and transgender subjectivities, I examine the way tombois and their girlfriends produce a sense of themselves in relation to and distinction from national and transnational queer discourses. In the following, I sketch tombois' and their girlfriends' self-representations and then explore the intersections of their lives with global queer discourses. I address the ways tombois and their girlfriends represent themselves as masculine or feminine and the ways these subjectivities are informed by, resist, and reconstitute global queer discourses. In particular, I examine tombois' negotiation of the lesbi world (*dunia lesbi*) and activist discourse in ways that trouble activist efforts to establish particular sexual meanings. I argue that tombois' definitions of self contest the coherence of both lesbian and transgender identities as they are represented in Indonesian and Western LGBT discourse.

"We're Guys": Tomboi Self-Representations

A group of waria organized a birthday party on a Saturday evening for a young man who had just turned twenty-four years old.¹⁷ Several of the tombois, who are good friends with Fay, a leader of the waria organization, were invited to attend. The party is on the second floor of a house belonging to the birthday boy's older sister; the house is not yet finished but is cheerfully decorated for the party with crepe paper hangings, oriental rugs, and a colorful dais on which the birthday boy sits in his gold lamé pant suit. Danny, one of the tombois, whispers, "He's not waria; he's gay," to my inquiry about his identity, but most of the other invited attendees are waria. Sitting on the floor with me are three tombois, two girlfriends, and my research associate. Danny and h/er girlfriend sit close together but do not touch each other.¹⁸ Fay, wearing a tight, short, lacy black dress, is the MC for the evening. First we sing happy birthday and are offered cake and a cold juice drink. Then the waria fashion show starts. Several waria dressed in ball gowns, their hair elegantly styled, sashay down the middle of the room one at a time. As the evening wears on, the room gets more and more crowded with onlookers who jam the door-

way and spill into the room. Among the onlookers are many boys and young men, a few girls, and some older neighbors and relatives of the birthday boy. One game we play involves passing a CD around while the music plays. Whoever is caught holding the CD when the music stops has to pop a balloon hung in the middle of the floor and carry out the sentence (*hukum*) written on a piece of paper inside the balloon. When one of the waria gets caught, h/is sentence is to dance with a partner. H/e asks Fay if h/is dance partner can be a guy (*cowok*) and Fay says yes, so h/e picks another waria, and they dance together in the middle of the room. Danny turns to me, laughing, and says, “A guy? That’s a girl! We’re guys” (*Cowok? Itu cewek! Kami cowok*). Danny’s comment playfully rejects the young waria’s use of *guy* for h/is partner, asserting that tombois, not waria, are the guys in the room.

The subject positions that tombois and their girlfriends take up are informed by a wide array of global discourses at the same time that these subject positions respond to localized discourses. The city of Padang, which sits on the coast of West Sumatra in Indonesia, is a sprawling metropolis of more than seven hundred thousand people. It has been a major trading port in Southeast Asia for hundreds of years. Located near the equator, this sultry city is currently the provincial capital of West Sumatra and a province of the state of Indonesia. A regional metropolis, Padang is cosmopolitan and globally connected, but it occupies an intermediate position as a metropolis based on its size relative to other cities in Indonesia and its status as a provincial capital, active trade center, and port. Jakarta is the dominant metropolis of Indonesia, with a population of well over 8 million. Padang is the third-largest city on the island of Sumatra after Medan and Palembang. Its intermediate position as a metropolitan location makes it an intriguing place to study global sexualities. In a field in which global gay metropolitan centers are usually considered centers of and standards for queer sexualities, Padang is neither a global metropolis nor a nonmetropolitan area.¹⁹ I use the term *metropolitan* for Padang as one way to contest its supposed location on the margins of queer space “outside” metropolitan areas.

During 2001 and 2004, I conducted extensive research on lesbi subjectivities in Padang. I met twenty-eight individuals who were either tombois or girlfriends of tombois.²⁰ Of those twenty-eight, I formally interviewed sixteen individuals.²¹ I spent time with them in the spaces that they inhabited, including their work spaces as well as their social spaces. I collected detailed life histories and asked questions that addressed how they understand themselves and their world. The lesbi participants come from a range of socioeconomic backgrounds, from quite poor to ordinary or average households, with two tipping toward well-to-do. People in West Sumatra typically refer to three classes, *kaya*, *biasa*, and *miskin*

(rich, ordinary folk, and poor), designations that are associated primarily with levels of income. Household incomes are relevant to understanding these individuals because, like most unmarried Indonesians, they live with their natal kin or close relatives and in some cases work in the family business. Of the twenty-two for whom I was able to obtain demographic data, slightly more than two-thirds (fifteen) come from roughly the same class location, an intermediate strata, to use Kenneth Young's term, while the rest are from poorer families.²² Most of the families of these lesbi have limited income or property and little surplus for leisure activities or family ceremonies, reflecting Richard Robison's definition of a lower middle class.²³ This class location is an important factor in constituting the particular readings that lesbi in West Sumatra make of gendered and sexual discourses.

Being lesbi in Padang is generally understood as an expression of gender rather than a form of sexuality engaged in by two women.²⁴ By this I mean that a lesbi couple comprises two individuals who express distinctly different genders. Tombois do not see themselves as women; they consider themselves masculine or like men. I asked Tommy, a tomboi in h/er mid-twenties, how guys treat her. S/he said, "They consider me a guy and treat me like one, not like a female. That's also because I consider myself a guy." In regard to h/er family, Tommy said, "My family understands that I'm more like a guy, even to the extent of sleeping [overnight] anywhere I want. It's not a problem. They know I can protect myself." When asked how s/he sees h/erself, Robi, another tomboi, answered, "I feel like a guy because my behavior is more like a guy. Really, there is no difference between me and men. We're the same." Tombois are marked by their short hair, their rowdy, boisterous behavior, and their habit of smoking in public.

Tombois' performances of masculinity include the ability to move in spaces dominated by men, to work in men's jobs, and to participate in certain "manly" behaviors that are disallowed for women, such as smoking, drinking, and staying over at friends' houses. The ability to access some of men's privileges and to move in the men's world provides further evidence to tombois of their status as men. The men's world in Padang is found in the public spaces predominantly occupied by men, such as cafés, pool halls, bars, street corners, and for the more religious, the *surau* or prayer house where religious studies and devotions are held and where young men often sleep. Being able to participate in the men's world substantiates their sense of self as masculine. Dedi claimed that h/er family recognized s/he was a tomboi because s/he was sleeping "here and there." For young unmarried men in Padang this pattern means that they are generally free from familial supervision and control. Tommi's statement above that s/he can sleep overnight anywhere s/he wants substantiates h/er ability to move in the men's world.

When I asked Tommi whether there was any difference between h/erself and men, s/he said, “No, nothing.” S/he thought about it a little more and continued, “No, we’re the same . . . because the jobs I like are those that men do.” For Tommi, h/er work interests are another indicator of h/er identification with men. The everyday activities that tombois emphasize as part of their masculine life included sleeping anywhere (especially not at home), doing anything they want, associating with whomever they want, going out, traveling alone, staying out late, doing men’s work, smoking and drinking, and hanging out with men.

In contrast to tombois, girlfriends, who dress in the same style as other women in West Sumatra, are generally polite, restrained, and considerate in public. In fact, girlfriends see themselves as indistinguishable from other women. Jeni, who was twenty-three at the time, explained to me, “I am the same as other women. I wear feminine clothes, sometimes even skirts, and put on makeup.” She defined women as “neat, polite, and warm-hearted.” Being “the same as other women” referred not only to the attributes they possess but the occupations they take up. Nila and Jeni manage a food stall, for which they do all the cooking themselves. Another is a maid, a fourth a seamstress. In addition to their occupations, they prioritize domestic interests. Epi said, “I like to cook a lot—things like cake and cookies [*kué*].” Jeni said she liked to take walks, cook, and read popular magazines when she’s not busy. Girlfriends define themselves as normative women who are attracted to men; they happen to be lesbi at this point because their boyfriends are female bodied.

Tombois’ and girlfriends’ views of each other join together in supporting their differences. Nila, who thinks of herself as timid, sees tombois as show-offs. “Like other women,” Jeni said, “girlfriends like a lot of attention. They like to be loved and spoiled.” Tombois, in contrast, “are just like guys. They can be very crude and egotistical,” according to Jeni. Noni said that tombois are not afraid of anything, but for her, “I’m very afraid to go out at night alone. I’m a woman. Someone might try to rape me!” Girlfriends speak of their relationships in heteronormative terms, finding the masculine traits of their partners desirable. Jeni said, “With Andri [her tomboi partner], I feel safe and protected.” Their traits and desires accord well with the gendered expectations for men and women. By demonstrating that they are not what women are, tombois feel confident in their knowledge of themselves as men. At the same time, girlfriends do not need to question their own desires because their self-presentation of femininity properly contrasts with that of the tombois.

All the comments above underscore the reality of binary gender for these individuals and the importance of maintaining difference. Lesbi in Padang envi-

sion themselves as either masculine or feminine, men or women. They prefer to use slang terms such as *cowok* and *cewek*, meaning “guy” and “girl,” for masculine and feminine partners, respectively.²⁵ As Danny’s remark at the party demonstrates, these two words are preferred by Padang lesbi when talking about each other. On another occasion when I organized a trip for several tombois and their partners, I heard Andri, another tomboi, say “Girls first!” (*Cewek dulu!*), as s/he stepped gallantly to the side to let the girlfriends board the waiting van. These terms describe tombois and their partners in specifically gendered ways, bringing into being and reinforcing for each a gendered sense of self that contrasts with one’s partner.

Falling into the Lesbian World

Although tombois and their girlfriends place themselves at opposite ends of a gender spectrum, they see themselves at the same time as part of a lesbi world (*dunia lesbi*) that intersects in varying ways and to varying degrees with national and transnational queer discourses and movements. The means by which these discourses circulate globally are quite varied, although Western queer studies tend to privilege activist movements and the Internet as primary sites of knowledge transmission. Other forms of media carry queer knowledge, including newspapers, magazines, and films, albeit typically couched in negative terms, but still offering the possibility of imagining difference. In this way queer knowledge and discourse circulate in Indonesia. Since the early 1980s, Indonesian media attention to an increasingly international gay and lesbian movement brought into common use the terms *lesbi* and *gay*, derived from the English terms *lesbian* and *gay*.²⁶ Stories about abusive or suicidal lesbian couples, the love interests of internationally famous lesbian and gay figures, and reports of same-sex marriage and sex-reassignment surgeries offered an understanding of nonnormative sexualities not available in everyday discourse. These stories provided a major source of information about lesbian, gay, and transgender identities and lifestyles to Indonesian youth.²⁷

Other sites of knowledge transmission are the small urban communities of lesbi, gay, and waria, each with their own particular knowledges and their different connections to global queer discourses.²⁸ *Waria* is one of the Indonesian terms for male-bodied individuals who act like women and take men as lovers. In Indonesia generally, waria are well-known to most people, from their work as wedding planners or hairdressers, from their fashion show performances or their roles in popular forms of Javanese theater and on television series.²⁹ In cities including

Padang, as noted above, waria have their own organizations and occasionally put on balls and beauty contests that draw on and attend to national and international fashion and global drag performances. Many waria have traveled and worked in cities throughout Indonesia and neighboring countries.³⁰

Within these urban communities are activist groups who model themselves after and gain resources from international lesbian and gay organizations. While waria have been acknowledged and visible in Indonesia for many decades, particularly in association with theater, the early 1980s saw the appearance (and disappearance) of several small organizations, primarily on the island of Java, formed by individuals who identified as gay or lesbi.³¹ One of the longest-lasting groups, GAYa Nusantara, which is primarily a gay group but has included a few lesbi and waria, was organized in the mid-1980s. The first lesbian group was organized and disbanded in the early 1980s.³² Since 1998, two activist lesbian organizations, Swara Srikandi, the Internet-based lesbian group in Jakarta, and Sector 15 of the Indonesian Women's Coalition (Koalisi Perempuan Indonesia, KPI), have developed a significant presence in Indonesia. The Indonesian Women's Coalition was established to support women's issues and defend women's rights. It has actively pushed to insert human rights, women's rights, and minority sexual rights into the Indonesian constitution. These organizations, usually headed by well-educated, well-traveled, English-speaking activists from the upper echelons of Indonesian society, have looked to the lesbian and gay movements and literatures of Europe and the United States for models and resources but have also created their own Indonesian understanding of gender and sexual identities. Both gay and lesbi organizations evidence their connections to Western gay discourse through their newsletters and Web sites, which contain translations or English-language academic and political treatises on sexual orientation and sexual rights, as well as reviews of predominantly English-language gay and lesbian literature, news of gay rights marches, and listings of U.S. or European movies with gay or lesbian content.

Where activist knowledge circulates in Indonesia primarily through newsletters and Internet Web sites, these circuits are unavailable to lower-middle- and working-class lesbi in Padang because they do not have the computer knowledge or disposable income to be able to routinely access the Internet and are fearful of receiving or possessing written publications that might identify them as lesbi. For those not linked directly to international lesbian and gay organizations and not actively participating in or seeking information from national activist groups, access to queer discourses comes primarily through their interactions with waria individuals and organizations and through the travel of tombois between Padang and other metropolitan communities of Indonesia, primarily Jakarta and Medan.

During the 1980s and 1990s, this information traveled to West Sumatra by word of mouth as tombois visited or lived for brief periods of time in Jakarta and elsewhere in Indonesia. Thus queer knowledge circulates unevenly in Indonesia, less dependent on institutional spaces or publications than on the everyday interactions and travels of lesbi, gay, and waria individuals.

Travel is important, as Inderpal Grewal and Caren Kaplan note, because it is “part of the knowledge production through which subjects are constituted.”³³ Because tombois travel more widely and with less supervision than their girlfriends, much of the queer knowledge that comes to Padang is through tombois’ interactions with lesbi, gay, and waria in other cities. Such interactions occur primarily in working-class contexts and public spaces.³⁴ Jakarta is one of the global queer spaces known for its gay cruising areas and locales in malls or nightclubs where lesbi, gay, and waria meet each other.³⁵ One tomboi, who lived with h/er relatives in Jakarta off and on for two years, went to some of the bars and hangouts in Jakarta where gay or lesbi congregated. Another tomboi from Padang lives in Jakarta, returning home only occasionally with the latest conversations about lesbi subjectivities that circulate in h/er space in Jakarta.³⁶

One of the best ways to illustrate the uneven circulation and reception of queer knowledge is to track the movement of particular linguistic terms and phrases. The term *lesbi* has been available since the 1980s; it is used popularly to refer to same-sex attraction between women and to masculine women who have women lovers. A lesbi is not the same as a tomboi, however, because the term *tomboi*, which refers to gender behavior, does not necessarily connote sexuality, while the term *lesbi* does.³⁷ All the individuals I interviewed have known of the term *lesbi* since they were in grade school. Some were taunted with the word when schoolmates suspected they were too intimate with another girl. Tommi’s one boyfriend, whom s/he dated for a short time while s/he was in junior high school, called h/er a “lesbi” when s/he refused to kiss him. *Lesbi* was also the term that tombois vehemently denied if relatives or siblings became suspicious of a sexual or dating relationship with a woman. Not surprisingly, tombois prefer to use the term *lines* rather than *lesbi*. *Lines* is a slang word from waria vernacular that is used in place of *lesbi*, particularly in public spaces, so that outsiders are unaware of what is being discussed. The consistency of usage of this term among lesbi in Padang, even in more private spaces, suggests that it has become their preferred identifier.

The terms *lesbi*, *lesbian*, and *gay* were taken up by lesbi and gay groups in Jakarta as their identifiers even in the early 1980s despite media-influenced associations with deviance, crime, and illness.³⁸ Consequently these terms circulated not only in the media but on the streets and among the social networks of those

in same-sex relationships.³⁹ PERLESIN (Persatuan Lesbian Indonesia), the first lesbian organization, used the word *lesbian* in its title; it was founded by individuals who identified as masculine.⁴⁰ The founder of GAYa Nusantara, the Cornell-educated linguist Dédé Oetomo, established a direct link between Western gay discourse and his own activist efforts in Indonesia. Oetomo stated that his use of the terms *gay* and *lesbian* in Indonesian followed the terms as used in (1980s) gay America.⁴¹ GAYa Nusantara adopted a triangle, within which were the letters G, A, Y, as the symbol for the organization. In the first edition of the GAYa Nusantara newsletter Oetomo defined *gay* and *lesbian* as people who are attracted to the same sex, that is, a woman to a woman and a man to a man.⁴² KPI's Sector 15, reflecting the 1990s international sexual rights discourse, used the phrase "minority sexual orientation" to define its members, and included in that category lesbians, bisexuals, and transgender individuals.⁴³ Swara Srikandi defined *lesbian* as a "woman who is sexually oriented to other women."⁴⁴ In appropriating Western labels, these groups lay claim to certain meanings attached to those labels, but they were not simply imitating Western identities. Rather activists tended to rely on those terms and definitions as a way to validate their own existence and connect with a global movement.

Tombois who traveled to Jakarta, like Tommi, heard the word *lesbi* used by others like themselves in places where lesbi and gay congregated. Tommi mentioned to me that a lesbi activist in Jakarta had appeared on an Indonesian television program and had come out as a lesbi. Then s/he said, "People are beginning to understand about us," signaling that s/he identifies h/erself with the term *lesbi*. But the activist definition of *lesbi* as "women who are attracted to women" was not the meaning she attached to the word. The prevalence of "butch" lesbians in working-class contexts helped bolster tombois' view of themselves as lesbi who are like men.⁴⁵ As I tried to make sense of the meaning of *lesbi* in Padang, Tommi explained to me, "A lesbi is a woman with a woman. But tombois are included as well." Tommi first provided the definition endorsed and promoted by activist organizations, but by adding tombois to the definition, s/he included them under the label *lesbi*, even though s/he sees h/erself as a man. When asked why s/he sees h/erself as lesbi, Tommi replied, "because I fell in love with a woman," creating a connection between lesbi and tombois' desires for women. Girlfriends are also included under the label *lesbi* because they are with someone who is a tomboi. Tommi's girlfriend, Lina, said, "A woman with a tomboi is definitely a lesbi." For girlfriends, this attraction is consonant with their attraction to men in general, which makes them the "same as" other (heterosexual) women and yet different. Their desire for tombois brings them under the label *lesbi*.

At the same time that they stand under the label *lesbi*, tombois and girlfriends shift its meaning. Explaining who is included in the category of lesbi, Robi, a tomboi, said, “Lesbi includes those who are masculine and feminine.”⁴⁶ Because partners are differently gendered, a lesbi in their understanding of the term is not a woman attracted to other women but a female who is attracted to the other gender. *Lesbi* in this sense identifies both partners as female-bodied, but at the same time it serves as an umbrella term that incorporates their different subjectivities. For tombois and girlfriends, the label *lesbi* includes individuals with different histories and different routes into the lesbi world. *Lesbi* then serves as an identifier, signifying a group that occupies a space distinct from the rest of the world. Consequently, *lesbi* as a circulating category is not a stable term throughout Indonesia but is appropriated and reconstituted to fit particular meanings.

Other idioms circulate in lesbi, gay, and waria circles in Jakarta and travel to West Sumatra to become part of tombois’ and girlfriends’ speech. Gay men in Jakarta use the phrase “falling into the gay world” (*terjun ke dunia gay*) to describe becoming involved with another man.⁴⁷ Howard states that these men, who were part of a gay men’s social organization created in 1992 by poorer, lower-status men, describe a homosexuality that is contingent on spatial and temporal contexts, taking place in “a gay world” and not outside it. The phrase “the lesbian world,” which appeared in various newsletters published by lesbi organizations in the 1990s and 2000s and in a lesbian section of GAYa Nusantara, employs the same concept of a separate world, in this case for lesbi. This phrase traveled to Padang via tombois such as Tommi, who had spent nearly two years in Jakarta and used it the most often, but others, both tombois and their girlfriends, were familiar with the term and used it occasionally. When talking about a young woman who had become involved with her first tomboi, one tomboi said, “[She] fell into the lesbian world.” This phraseology signifies movement from the everyday world of family and kin into a new world populated by others like themselves. Girlfriends are seen as “falling into” the lesbi world, while their tomboi partners seem always to have been there. *Dunia lesbi* is not the world of tombois, however, but the world of lesbi couples, both tombois and their girlfriends. While Jakarta activists imagine this world to be composed of women attracted to other women, in Padang the same terminology is used for a world comprising individuals with two very different subjectivities: that of normatively female/women (the girlfriends) and physically female/men (the tombois).

Lesbi in Padang are also familiar with the English words *butch* and *femme*, which they encounter via tomboi connections with lesbi individuals or communities in Jakarta. Lesbi in Padang do not incorporate the two terms into their everyday

speech, preferring to use their own Indonesian slang words. Importantly, however, they believe that *butch* and *femme* are cognates, respectively, of *cowok* and *cewek*, the terms they use to refer to each other. Knowledge of the English words and their imagined association with the Indonesian words create a sense of connection with lesbian communities far beyond West Sumatra and Indonesia. These particular words also facilitate a sense that individuals in these communities share the same gendered desires and meanings, creating a world in which everyone is positioned as either tomboi or girlfriend.

Thus *dunia lesbi* is not localized but inclusive of a lesbian world populated by global others. In the selective reception of queer knowledge these others are read as sharing the same understanding of lesbi as those in Padang. Photos I brought with me of my lesbian friends in the United States were pored over to ascertain who were the tombois and the femmes. Famous lesbians such as Martina Navratilova and Melissa Etheridge, whose stories of betrayal by femme lovers are well-known in Indonesia, secure a strong connection between lesbi in Padang and a global *dunia lesbi*. Both women are read as butches and their girlfriends as femmes who, unsurprisingly to tombois in Padang, left their partners for men. Thus while the circulation of such terms as *lesbi*, *butch*, and *femme*, as well as images of famous lesbians, connect tombois and their girlfriends to a global lesbian world, these terms and images are read in a way that supports a gendered construction of sexuality. In the circulation of queer knowledge, lesbi in Padang use their own culturally available models to interpret global queer discourses and arrive at meanings that make sense to them, creating their own particular version of *dunia lesbi*.

Marking Transgender, Displacing Tombois

While in Jakarta for a short visit in 2004, I met several women members of Sector 15 at their office in a neighborhood in south Jakarta. We sat in the main room, a long open space with tables, desks, and bookcases stacked with piles of papers, several computers and monitors in various stages of use and disuse, posters hung on the walls, and bulletin boards cluttered with flyers and announcements. I talked briefly with one woman, who is university educated, in her mid-thirties, and working for a social agency. Lin has short hair and was wearing casual clothes, including a polo shirt and trousers. Although she speaks English, she was more comfortable speaking to me in Indonesian. She said, “I identify as ‘no label’ or ‘andro’ because I don’t feel either too masculine or too feminine. I’m a woman who loves a woman [*perempuan cinta perempuan*].” I asked if she thought there was

a difference between lesbi and tomboi, so she explained, “There are lesbi who are butchie or femme, but the primary thing is they feel like women. Even some ‘no label’ can look somewhat like tombois, like I do, but it’s not complete.” I had started the conversation by asking about tombois, but as we talked Lin inserted the word *transgender*. She said, “Transgender is someone who doesn’t want h/er body touched. That person would not be considered under the umbrella of lesbi. Lesbi pleasure each other, but a transgender person doesn’t enjoy being touched, s/he is the one doing the touching [*aktif*]. When I first came out in high school, I thought I had to be a tomboi, so I acted more like that. But I’ve read lots since then and decided I could be a woman and love another woman, so I changed how I think about myself.” Lin’s story speaks to shifts in her own self-perception as she acquires certain knowledge, through reading, about lesbian identity. She does not attribute her knowledge directly to Western lesbian discourse, but her statements echo a particular historical version of that discourse with its notions of coming out, woman-loving-woman, and mutual sexual pleasuring that at the same time rejects too-masculine women.⁴⁸ While the term *lesbi* in her mind is somewhat fluid, containing *butchie*, *femme*, *andro*, and *no label*, which are the terms used in Indonesian, it excludes “tombois” because they are thought to be like men. As I discuss in this section, her narrative reveals the operation and reception of a global queer discourse whose appeal as an originary model underwrites an idealized lesbian identity refigured into Indonesian categories by lesbian activists.

The category “transgender” made its appearance on the global stage in the 1990s and was taken up by activist lesbian groups in Jakarta as a way to distinguish male-identified individuals from lesbians. Prior to that time the reception of waria and tombois within the growing gay and lesbian movements in Indonesia had been inconsistent at best, reflecting earlier trends in global queer discourse. Some of the erasures in this discourse were particularly disabling for lesbian and female transgender subjects, who were less visible in global gay (male) movements and narrowly defined in global lesbian-feminist rights movements during the 1990s.⁴⁹ Bacchetta explains how lesbian international nongovernmental organizations (INGOs), despite internal debates, were generally oriented toward issues pertaining to “out” lesbians and ignored other forms of lesbian subjectivities that did not conform closely to “dominant-sector European ideals of lesbian identity.”⁵⁰ Katie King points out that in some global lesbian feminist writing, as exemplified in Monika Reinfelder’s *Amazon to Zami*, *lesbian* came to be defined as “lifelong, stable after ‘coming out,’ autonomous of heterosexuality, sex-centered, politically feminist, not situational, and exclusive of marriage.”⁵¹

Coming out of the 1970s lesbian feminist period in the United States, this

definition of *lesbian* had global consequences for female-bodied sexual subjects. According to King, the lesbian feminist political claim that “lesbians don’t ape heterosexuals” attained a global coherence that delegitimated butch-femme pairings and distanced framings of lesbian identity from “local” versions of that pairing. Indonesian activists dealt with the unwieldy fit of tombois and waria in ways that reflected global categories and understandings of sexuality. Oetomo suggested that *waria* (also called *banci*) was a traditional, lower-class identity, while *homo* or *gay* were modern constructions.⁵² Similarly, Gayatri, a lesbian feminist activist who spearheaded the short-lived group Chandra Kirana in the early 1990s, claimed that masculine-acting tombois did not fit with contemporary lesbi identities.⁵³ Drawing on the lesbian feminist rejection of masculine-acting women, Gayatri specifically excluded “female-transvestites” (her English translation) from her research on lesbians in Indonesia because she felt that their identification as men separated them from lesbians.⁵⁴ In the emerging lesbian activist movement, tombois were perceived as imitating men and hence in need of modernization and education.⁵⁵ Gayatri softened her stance over time and came to include “butch-femme roles” (equated with tombois) within the category of lesbian, but the masculine lesbi continued to trouble activist circles.⁵⁶

By the early 2000s lesbian activist organizations began to consolidate the term *lesbian* around the originary ideal of Euro-American lesbianism by defining lesbians as women-loving-women while using the term *transgender* for those tombois who identify as men. Here I recount attempts by lesbian activists to recategorize Indonesian subjectivities as new Western terms enter the Indonesian activist lexicon, and the resulting tensions created by the shift in terms. My discussion focuses on efforts to affix labels, not on the sexual identities of the activists themselves. Even among activists, the subjectivities they take up are more complex and diverse than the labels they endorse, as Lin’s narrative suggests. My discussion of these labels is not meant to suggest that lesbi activists in Jakarta blindly endorse transnational queer discourse, nor does their claim to those labels reflect an elitist stance.⁵⁷

As with tombois’ reception of transnational queer discourse, activists make sense of proffered sexual identities within the context of their particular location. The women in these Jakarta-based organizations generally, but not always, have university educations, professional jobs, and various levels of proficiency in English. In addition they rely on the Internet for information and connections with other lesbi in Jakarta and globally. My information on activist organizations came from participation in their meetings and informal discussions with a few members and leaders of these organizations in 2001 and 2004 as well as from their literature, Web sites,

and listservs. Discussions with members focused on the strategies, goals, and constituents of the organizations themselves and not on the individual members or how they identified, although this was sometimes brought up in conversation.

Since the late 1990s, lesbian activist organizations began to receive funding from international lesbian and women's organizations, such as Astraea and Global Fund for Women. Although Swara Srikandi began without any international support, international funding has allowed for expanded services and travel to national and international Asian LGBT conferences, where they have been able to plug into global LGBT networks.⁵⁸ These networks emphasize a discourse of equality, human rights, and the rights of "sexual minorities," the English term used by KPI, as they work to make a difference in the lives of women and lesbians. According to Lin, "The strategy for Sector 15 is to publicize our existence by getting info about lesbians into the media. Almost nothing is known or written about lesbi in Indonesia, just about homo men." While working to find a space for masculine-identified tombois, Sector 15 as well as Swara Srikandi advocate models of sexual identity and visibility in line with certain Western and feminist models of sexuality and sexual rights. These models contest the subjectivities and relationships of tombois and their girlfriends.⁵⁹

The repositioning of masculine-identified tombois by lesbi activists was articulated clearly by Wina in the first issue of Swara Srikandi's monthly newsletter (*Lembar Swara*), which began publication in May 2003. Wina (the pseudonym she uses) is one of the founders and leaders of Swara Srikandi. Titled "Terms/Expressions of the LGBT World," her article offered an unambiguous set of definitions for the terms *lesbian*, *gay*, *bisexual*, and *transgender*.⁶⁰ According to Wina, the article was written in hopes of resolving any confusion for her readers about the meanings of these terms. Wina, a thirty-something professional woman who wears feminine attire to work (skirt, blouse, dress jacket, and low heels), converses easily in English. She defines herself as andro, neither butch nor femme, and is apparently comfortable in both her work attire and her more casual jeans.

In the article Wina distinguishes between "butch" lesbians and "FTM transgender." She defines the former as "a lesbian who in appearance is a tomboi [*berpenampilan tomboi*], is masculine [*kelaki-lakian*], and prefers men's clothes (men's shirts, long pants, very short hair), however, DON'T FORGET that while a butch is a tomboi, she [*dia*] considers herself a woman and doesn't have a problem being a woman or hate her body."⁶¹ Wina defines FTM transgender as a "female who feels that she is a man and frequently thinks about becoming a man." She then explains the difference between the two terms as follows: a butch dresses and acts like a man "but still considers herself to be a woman [*perempuan*] and

does not hate her female body,” while “transgender [FTM] is a foreign term for a woman who feels that s/he is a man” and “feels trapped in a female body that s/he does not like.”⁶² To make sure that readers understand, Wina capitalizes the following text: “TRANSGENDER FTM IS NOT A LESBIAN.” Wina goes on to note that people in general often confuse the two “because a transgender FTM person does not dress any differently than a butch lesbian.” However, she hopes that readers “will finally understand and make the distinction that a butch is not transgender, as long as she feels strongly that she is a woman.”⁶³ In her narrative *FTM transgender* is the only term said to be “foreign,” while *lesbian*, *gay*, *bisexual*, and *butch* are unmarked, indicating their longer history of usage in Indonesia and in the activist movement itself. Her article points to the recent acquisition of *transgender* from international LGBT discourse and its acceptance as a relevant term for Indonesian identities despite its foreign origin.

Transgender as a global term is being used here to resolve a perceived conflict between the meanings of *lesbian* and *tomboi*. With the arrival of the term *transgender* and the authoritative weight that it carries as an originary term of the global gay movement, Wina argues for a distinction that divides tombois into FTM transgender individuals and butch lesbians based on how they think about their bodies. According to Wina, to be a lesbi a tomboi must consider herself a woman. If she considers herself a man, then she is not a lesbian, or a butch, but an FTM transgender person. Yet Wina’s discussion of butch lesbians and FTM transgender individuals shows that the two are quite similar in appearance and dress. Her insistence on distinguishing between the two evinces the discomfort felt by activist women for whom tomboi is a troubling and ambiguous category. Despite the activists’ desire to use gender difference as an authoritative way of managing this uncertainty, Wina’s comment that people cannot really tell the difference between a butch lesbian and a transgender FTM person by looking at them nevertheless points to the ambiguity of the category tomboi. Following Wina’s statement, Swara Srikandi reorganized their Web site to serve the needs of lesbians and bisexual women only, while excluding FTM transgender.

The other lesbian activist group, Sector 15, does not exclude FTM transgender individuals from its group, but it too defines *transgender* as something very different from *lesbi*. As Lin recounted earlier, the category of tomboi is replaced by a clear distinction between butchie lesbians and transgender people. Lesbians are women, transgender people (FTMs) are not. Further distinctions are made on the basis of their sexual preferences. According to Lin, FTMs are like men because they are the active partner in sexuality (“the one doing the touching”) rather than the coparticipant (“pleasuring each other”). Lin’s self-description of

becoming a lesbian situates her tomboi-ness as pre-lesbi, the identity she took on before she “knew” more about lesbians through reading. The circuits of knowledge she accesses through reading take the form of English-language books, articles, and Web sites on lesbian/gay identity and lesbian/gay issues, since such literature in Indonesian is generally unavailable. In line with global LGBT discourse, the tomboi comes to occupy the space of premodernity for Lin, the space before this new knowledge took hold. This activist discourse seeks to speak for all Indonesian lesbians at the same time that it distances itself from transgender FTMs and tombois.

Queer Knowledge, Multiple Receptions

While queer knowledge circulated unevenly among Indonesian lesbi in the 1980s and 1990s, by the late 1990s this circulation began to change form and intensify as international funding allowed activist lesbian organizations to develop broader connections beyond the island of Java. KPI in particular initiated contact with lesbi on other islands through meetings and the establishment of branch organizations, including one located in Padang. The resultant shift in knowledge transmission put Padang lesbi into direct contact with these groups and their discourse of sexual identity and sexual rights. The following exchange provides further insights into the selective reception of queer knowledge and the diversity of lesbi, gay, and waria subjectivities in Indonesia.

Leaders of the Padang branch of Sector 15 were invited to attend the national KPI conference in Jakarta in early 2004.⁶⁴ After receiving funds to help cover the costs, Dedi decided to make the trip as a representative of the new branch. During this conference a conversation between Dedi and one of the activists took place that revealed some of the tensions and asymmetries in queer knowledge. The lesbian activist, one of the leaders of Sector 15 in Jakarta, had some fluency in English and training from a university overseas. Dedi, one of the tombois I worked with, was a high school graduate, nearing thirty, who worked for h/her family in Padang. Dedi was eager to make connections with other lesbi beyond Padang and was willing to risk being known as a lesbi, at least among women at the conference in Jakarta. The conversation between Dedi and the activist was witnessed by my research associate.

Activist: “What do you consider yourself to be, a man or a woman?”

Dedi: “I’m like a man.”

A: “That means you’re not a lesbian. You’re transgender.”

On recounting the story to me later that year, Dedi said, “I didn’t say anything then [in response]. I didn’t understand ‘transgender.’ I’d never heard of it before. But it doesn’t matter, I know how I feel.” Curious about h/er impressions of the lesbi she met in Jakarta, I asked Dedi if s/he noticed a difference between lesbi in Jakarta and lesbi in Padang. Dedi said, “No, they’re the same as in Padang, femmes and tombois. You can see it in their appearance. The only difference is the femmes in Jakarta can smoke but in Padang they’re not allowed to. When I first met Lin I had a hard time distinguishing between her and her partner, which one was femme [*peré*] and which one tomboi, because Lin smokes and carries herself like a tomboi. I had to ask [another activist who had moved to Jakarta from Padang], then I knew.”

In the initial conversation, the activist tries to resituate Dedi within national and global understandings of gender and sexuality, but without success. Dedi is oblivious to the term *transgender* and appears to be unconcerned that s/he is expected to identify as transgender. Despite being introduced to the term and encouraged to think of herself as transgender, Dedi returns to Padang with h/er own categories intact. On being asked to reflect about what s/he saw in Jakarta, she reveals that s/he did not see any difference: Jakarta lesbi closely resemble Padang lesbi.

At the same time that lesbian activists in Jakarta are inserting tombois into the category transgender, lesbi in West Sumatra find this recategorization unintelligible. The lack of reception of activist discourse here is striking. Dedi admits of no difference, even though in the beginning s/he had trouble fitting the activist lesbi into h/er own binary categories. The Padang lesbi from whom she asked for clarification confirmed what s/he thought she knew, that is, that there are only femmes and tombois. Although s/he had trouble at first identifying Lin as femme because Lin smoked, she was able to make sense of Lin’s position because Dedi knew that h/er female (and heterosexual) cousins in Jakarta had taken up smoking. As a global metropolis, Jakarta is seen as the space of “modernity,” different than places on other islands, which are viewed by Java-centric people as being somewhat more conservative. Thus femmes in Jakarta might smoke, whereas those in Padang “are not allowed to smoke” because it would be deemed improper for a woman to do so, yet they are both still recognizably femme in Dedi’s eyes.

Dedi’s inability to see “difference” hints at the vulnerability of h/er own position both in Padang and in the face of better-educated and better-traveled urban activists. By seeing only sameness, Dedi assures h/erself of h/er own familiar position in the world and in *dunia lesbi*. Being the same admits no other way

of being, no exceptions, and no deviation in the face of a repositioning, as “transgender,” that would otherwise raise some deeply troubling questions for h/er: If I’m transgender, what is my partner? Is she lesbi? Am I not lesbi? If lesbi are two “women,” where does that leave me? Do I not belong to the lesbi community? The meanings and experiences that signify being “lesbi” may differ for tombois and their girlfriends, but they consider each other to be part of the lesbi world. Shifting the definition of lesbi to exclude tombois who are like men calls into question tombois’ understandings of their own relationships as well as the comfort and security they feel in their lives as tombois. Hence tombois’ lack of reception of LGBT discourse in the form of the term *transgender* is not due to a lack of understanding of the term but to their own particular understandings of *dunia lesbi*.

Identities or subject positions that are culturally available in particular localities serve as the basis for negotiating with global gay discourse. While Jakartan activists orient their subject positions to the originary (Western) lesbian ideals defining lesbians as women who love women, in Padang tombois and their partners lay claim to the label *lesbi/lesbian* as a signifier for their relationships and community while rejecting the term *transgender* that has been proffered to them. Their use of the label *lesbi* belies originary models because it encompasses both tombois and their girlfriends. Despite activists’ efforts to resituate them, tombois’ and girlfriends’ subjectivities do not fit neatly with the sexual categories claimed by national activist groups.

Asymmetries of Queer Knowledge

In the complexity of cultural production, global flows, and transnational practices, queer discourses circulate unevenly and are accessed by lesbi in Padang in ways particular to their location. Until recently, their sexual subjectivities were not directly informed by the growing lesbian/gay movement in Indonesia or by the Internet, which have been viewed as some of the primary vehicles producing new sexual subjectivities. Even direct contact with activist lesbi in Jakarta did not alter at least one tomboi’s particular self-understanding as a lesbi. Because lesbi intercept the circuits of queer knowledge in class- and gender-delimited ways, their subjectivities reflect the particularities of place and the particular circuits they access, which is not to say they are therefore out of touch with “modern” forms of sexualities or in need of education. While their subjectivities are often imagined as premodern or lacking in modern “sexual” knowledge, the difference that tombois and their girlfriends represent is not the difference of outmoded gender-based sexualities. Their particular reception of queer discourse points to the asymme-

tries of knowledge production across gender and class.⁶⁵ I use the term *asymmetries* here, following Ann Stoler, because it does not infer lack or absence, which would suggest the existence of some correct form of LGBT discourse or knowledge correctly received. “Asymmetries” point to differences in reception and the consequent multiplicity of desires and subjectivities. These asymmetries disturb any claims about what are proper or even “modern” forms of same-sex desire. Despite their lack of access to new technologies and print media published by national and international lesbian and gay activist organizations, lesbi in Padang are not isolated from global networks; rather, they access these networks, and the queer knowledge they produce, through different means. Thus the lesbian activists as well as tombois and femmes each reflect the particularities and asymmetries of class, gender, and ethnicity in Indonesia as they intersect with transnational queer discourses.

Queer studies research suggests a complicated process at the intersection of global and local, characterized more by hybridity or syncretization than mimicry or reflection.⁶⁶ Manalansan’s work on Filipino gay men in the United States demonstrates how these men negotiate Filipino and U.S. American sexual and gender ideologies, taking into account both *bakla* and gay meanings in their self-constructions. According to Manalansan, the term *bakla* “encompasses homosexuality, hermaphroditism, cross-dressing, and effeminacy,” thus raising the possibility that these diverse subjectivities “are not moored to any fixed category.”⁶⁷ The subjectivities of lesbi activists, tombois, and their girlfriends demonstrate the disparate ways that global queer discourses are accessed, addressed, and exchanged.⁶⁸ Both are already part of and crucially connected with a global queer community, suggesting that queer subjectivities are not created in a simple melding of the globalized and the localized but through many different intersections within and between regions and nations. While their subjectivities reflect their particular location within national and transnational queer discourses and movements, their particular differences demonstrate the multiplicity of queer subjectivities in Indonesia and the importance of recognizing and validating these subjectivities.

Tombois and their partners challenge the coherence of both lesbian and transgender identities as they have been represented in global LGBT discourse. Through selective reception of transnational queer knowledges, lesbi in Padang produce subjectivities that differ from those claimed by national activist groups. The complexities of their subject positions make it impossible to align them with Western-defined categories of lesbian or transgender, pointing to the need to dismantle fixed gender and sexual categories that limit identities to LGBT. At the same time, the asymmetries of reception and the importance of ethnicity, class,

and gender to the production of particular gendered and sexual subjectivities demonstrate that there is neither a homogeneous global nor a national queer identity, suggesting that strategies to address sexual rights must be sensitive to the differences within and across groups, nations, and regions of the world.

Notes

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1. I follow Inderpal Grewal and Caren Kaplan's use of the term *transnational* as a way to move beyond an assumed Western point of origin. See Inderpal Grewal and Caren Kaplan, "Global Identities: Theorizing Transnational Studies of Sexuality," *GLQ* 7 (2001): 663–79.
2. Arnaldo Cruz-Malavé and Martin F. Manalansan IV, "Introduction: Dissident Sexualities/ Alternative Globalisms," in *Queer Globalizations: Citizenship and the Afterlife of Colonialism*, ed. Arnaldo Cruz-Malavé and Martin F. Manalansan IV (New York: New York University Press, 2002), 6. In fact, tracing queer globalization may unintentionally highlight European and U.S. origins. See, for instance, Jasbir Puar's identification of queer globalization processes in Trinidad operative within the multiple circuits of gay tourism, postcolonial gay identities, global gay cities, international HIV/AIDS activism, and global drag performances ("Global Circuits: Transnational Sexualities and Trinidad," *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society* 26 [2001]: 1039–65).
3. Paola Bacchetta, "Rescaling Transnational 'Queerdom': Lesbian and 'Lesbian' Identity-Positionalities in Delhi in the 1980s," *Antipode: A Radical Journal of Geography* 34 (2002): 947–73.
4. Grewal and Kaplan, "Global Identities."
5. See also Martin F. Manalansan IV, "In the Shadows of Stonewall: Examining Gay Transnational Politics and the Diasporic Dilemma," in *The Politics of Culture in the Shadow of Capital*, ed. Lisa Lowe and David Lloyd (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1997), 485–505; Cruz-Malavé and Manalansan, "Introduction"; Gayatri Gopinath, "Local Site/Global Contexts: The Transnational Trajectories of Deepa Mehta's *Fire*," in Cruz-Malavé and Manalansan, *Queer Globalizations*, 149–61.
6. Bacchetta, "Rescaling Transnational 'Queerdom,'" 952.
7. The B, or bisexual, tends to receive much less attention in activist discourse, while lesbian and gay are privileged.

8. *LGBT* is prominently used on the Web sites of, among many others, the International Lesbian and Gay Association (ILGA; www.ilga.org/index.asp) and the International Gay and Lesbian Human Rights Commission (IGLHRC; www.iglhrc.org/site/iglhrc/) (both accessed April 23, 2007).
9. See, e.g., "Third ILGA-Asia Regional Conference," which states that ILGA "recognizes the diverse ways by which genders and sexualities are experienced and defined in Asia" (asia.ilga.org/3rd_ilga_asia_regional_conference_chiang_mai_thailand_24_27_january_2008/about_the_conference [accessed December 10, 2007]).
10. Rebecca Dohrman, "Strategic Ambiguity at Work: A Thematic Analysis of the Use of Strategic Ambiguity in International Sexuality-Based Organizations' Websites" (unpublished paper, 2007).
11. Ruth Vanita, introduction to *Queering India: Same-Sex Love and Eroticism in Indian Culture and Society*, ed. Ruth Vanita (New York: Routledge, 2002), 1–11.
12. For studies of female same-sex desires, see Evelyn Blackwood and Saskia E. Wieringa, eds., *Female Desires: Same-Sex Relations and Transgender Practices across Cultures* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1999); Ruth Morgan and Saskia Wieringa, eds., *Tommy Boys, Lesbian Men, and Ancestral Wives: Female Same-Sex Practices in Africa* (Johannesburg: Jacana Media, 2005).
13. See Saskia E. Wieringa, Evelyn Blackwood, and Abha Bhaiya, eds., *Women's Sexualities and Masculinities in a Globalizing Asia* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2007).
14. See also Lisa Rofel, "Qualities of Desire: Imagining Gay Identities in China," *GLQ* 5 (1999): 451–74.
15. A good example of such a conference was the First International Conference of Asian Queer Studies held in Bangkok, Thailand, in July 2005 and sponsored by the Asia-PacificQueer Network of Sydney, Australia.
16. Vanita, introduction.
17. *Waria* is one of the Indonesian terms for male-bodied individuals who act like or are women and take men as lovers.
18. When referring to tombois (and waria), I use the pronominal constructions "s/he" and "h/er" ("h/e," "h/is") as a way to disrupt the binary genders of the English language. No English pronouns adequately convey the Indonesian usage, in which the third-person pronoun is gender neutral. This construction is not intended to mean "she-he" or to suggest a dual gender or combination of both woman and man. Other writers have chosen to use the English pronoun that seems to most closely resemble the person's gender identity, but to my mind that has the potential to reinsert transgressively gendered individuals into binary genders.
19. See, e.g., Alan Sinfield's discussion of metropolitan queer spaces, "The Production of Gay and the Return of Power," in *De-centring Sexualities: Politics and Representations beyond the Metropolis*, ed. Richard Phillips, Diane Watt, and David Shuttleton (London: Routledge, 2000), 21–36.

20. I refer to the women partners of tombois as “girlfriends” because they are seen by both tombois and themselves as lesbi only when they are involved with tombois. I also use the term *femme* as an identifier for girlfriends, despite and because of its connotations for English-speaking readers. See Joan Nestle, “The Femme Question,” in *The Persistent Desire: A Femme-Butch Reader*, ed. Joan Nestle (New York: Alyson Publications, 1992), 138–46. Indonesian words for girlfriend used by lesbi in Padang are *cewek* and *peré*, but as these are slang words that will undoubtedly change over time, I prefer *femme*. I use it to refer to normatively appearing women who are in this case attracted to tombois and normative men, and may or may not identify as lesbi.
21. Most people in West Sumatra speak two languages, Indonesian, the national language, and Minangkabau, the language of the region of West Sumatra. I conversed with research participants in Indonesian, while my Minangkabau research associate handled conversations in Minangkabau and provided translations for me. Most formal interviews were conducted in Indonesian, while general conversations in other spaces were a mix of Minang and Indonesian.
22. Kenneth Young, “Middle Bureaucrats, Middle Peasants, Middle Class? The Extra-Urban Dimension,” in *The Politics of Middle Class Indonesia*, Monash Papers on Southeast Asia, no. 19, ed. Richard Tanter and Kenneth Young (Clayton, Victoria: Monash University, 1990), 147–66.
23. Richard Robison, “The Middle Class and the Bourgeoisie in Indonesia,” in *The New Rich in Asia: Mobile Phones, McDonalds, and Middle-Class Revolution*, ed. Richard Robison and David S. G. Goodman (London: Routledge, 1996), 79–104.
24. For an analysis of their subjectivities in relation to hegemonic gender and sexuality in Indonesia, see Evelyn Blackwood, “Tombois in West Sumatra: Constructing Masculinity and Erotic Desire,” *Cultural Anthropology* 13 (1998): 491–521; Blackwood, “Transnational Sexualities in One Place: Indonesian Readings,” *Gender & Society* 19 (2005): 221–42; Blackwood, “Gender, Sexuality, and Queer Desires: Tombois and Femmes in Indonesia” (unpublished manuscript).
25. See Blackwood, “Tombois”; and Blackwood, “Gender, Sexuality, and Queer Desires.”
26. Tom Boellstorff, *The Gay Archipelago: Sexuality and Nation in Indonesia* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2005); Gayatri, “Indonesian Lesbians Writing Their Own Script: Issues of Feminism and Sexuality,” in *Amazon to Zami: Towards a Global Lesbian Feminism*, ed. Monika Reinfelder (London: Cassell, 1996), 86–97. *Gay* in Indonesian applies only to men. Although I have not researched the etymology of the term *tomboi* extensively, it was used in the 1980s in Indonesia but gained greater popularity in the 1990s as a term for a masculine lesbi.
27. A more detailed discussion of media representations of lesbi and gay is not possible here but see Blackwood, “Gender, Sexuality, and Queer Desires”; Boellstorff, *Gay Archipelago*; Gayatri, “Coming Out but Remaining Hidden: A Portrait of Lesbians in

- Java" (paper presented at the International Congress of Anthropological and Ethnological Sciences, Mexico City, Mexico, 1993).
28. See Alison J. Murray, "Let Them Take Ecstasy: Class and Jakarta Lesbians," in Blackwood and Wieringa, *Female Desires*, 139–56; and Saskia E. Wieringa, "Desiring Bodies or Defiant Cultures: Butch-Femme Lesbians in Jakarta and Lima," in Blackwood and Wieringa, *Female Desires*, 206–31.
 29. In *ludruk*, a form of Javanese theater, one of the stock characters is a male playing a woman. James Peacock (*Rites of Modernization: Symbolic Aspects of Indonesian Proletarian Drama* [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1968]) notes that these actors are also "effeminate" offstage, suggesting that they are transgender males. The male playing a female is a popular character with many fans.
 30. See Wieringa, "Desiring Bodies."
 31. See Boellstorff, *Gay Archipelago*; Richard Stephen Howard, *Falling into the Gay World: Manhood, Marriage, and Family in Indonesia* (PhD diss., University of Illinois, Urbana, 1996); Dédé Oetomo, *Memberi Suara pada yang Bisu (Giving Voice to the Mute)* (Yogyakarta: Galang, 2001); Wieringa, "Desiring Bodies."
 32. For the development of PERLESIN (Persatuan Lesbian Indonesia), the first lesbian organization in Indonesia, see Wieringa, "Desiring Bodies."
 33. Grewal and Kaplan, "Global Identities," 671.
 34. See Murray, "Let Them Take Ecstasy."
 35. Each issue of GAYa Nusantara contained a long list of places (*tempat ngeber*) where gay men or waria hang out, but none were mentioned for lesbi. See also Boellstorff, *Gay Archipelago*; Dédé Oetomo, "Gender and Sexual Orientation in Indonesia," in *Fantasizing the Feminine in Indonesia*, ed. Laurie Sears (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1996), 259–69.
 36. See also Oetomo, "Gender and Sexual Orientation."
 37. Oetomo notes that the same is true for the term *banci*, which he states is generally associated with a feminine gender identity and not sexual behavior. The term *banci* is considered somewhat derogatory and was countered by the creation of the term *waria*, which is a combination of the terms *wanita* (woman) and *pria* (man). See Oetomo, "Gender and Sexual Orientation."
 38. For media representations of lesbi and gay in the 1980s, see Gayatri, "Coming Out."
 39. Murray, "Let Them Take Ecstasy"; Wieringa, "Desiring Bodies." For the circulation of terms among gay organizations, see Boellstorff, *Gay Archipelago*; Howard, *Falling into the Gay World*.
 40. Wieringa, "Desiring Bodies."
 41. Oetomo, "Gender and Sexual Orientation."
 42. Dédé Oetomo, "Homoseksualitas di Barat dan di Indonesia" ("Homosexuality in the West and in Indonesia"), *GAYa Nusantara* 1 (1987): 9–20.

43. Sector 15 uses *minority sexual orientation* and *lesbian* in its English-language writings.
44. Wina, "Istilah/Sebutan dalam Dunia LGBT" ("Terms/Expressions of the LGBT World"), *Lembar Swara* 1 (2003): 8.
45. For working-class contexts, see Gayatri, "Sentul-kantil, Not Just Another Term: Kekayaan Relasi Gender Female-Homosexual Kontemporer di Jawa" ("The Diversity of Contemporary Female Homosexuality in Java") (unpublished manuscript, 1994); Murray, "Let Them Take Ecstasy."
46. Robi used the term *lines* rather than *lesbi*.
47. Howard, *Falling into the Gay World*.
48. On Western lesbian feminist discourse, see Katie King, "'There Are No Lesbians Here': Lesbians, Feminisms, and Global Gay Formations," in Cruz-Malavé and Manalansan, *Queer Globalizations*, 33–45.
49. See Evelyn Blackwood and Saskia E. Wieringa, "Globalization, Sexuality, and Silences: Women's Sexualities and Masculinities in an Asian Context," in Wieringa, Blackwood, and Bhaiya, *Women's Sexualities and Masculinities*, 1–20; Bacchetta, "Rescaling Transnational 'Queerdom,'" King, "There Are No Lesbians"; Megan Sinnott, "Public Sex: The Geography of Female Homoeroticism and the (In)Visibility of Female Sexualities," in *Out in Public: Lesbian and Gay Anthropology Confronts the Real World*, ed. Ellen Lewin and William Leap (New York: Blackwell, forthcoming).
50. Bacchetta, "Rescaling Transnational 'Queerdom,'" 950.
51. King, "There Are No Lesbians," 42; Reinfelder, *Amazon to Zami*.
52. Oetomo, "Gender and Sexual Orientation."
53. Gayatri, "Sentul-kantil."
54. Gayatri, "Coming Out," 17.
55. See also Murray, "Let Them Take Ecstasy"; Wieringa, "Desiring Bodies."
56. Gayatri, "Indonesian Lesbians," 91.
57. See also Vanita, introduction.
58. Some of the international travel funded for members of Swara Srikandi included trips to an Al-Fatiha (LGBT Muslim organization) conference in the United States, the International Lesbian and Gay Association–Asia (ILGA–Asia) conference, and Sydney (Australia) Gay Games and Global Rights Conference. Leaders of Sector 15 of KPI in Jakarta have attended international LGBT conferences and international training seminars in sexuality studies.
59. See also Saskia E. Wieringa, "'If There Is No Feeling . . .': The Dilemma between Silence and Coming Out in a Working Class Butch/Fem Community in Jakarta," in *Love and Globalization: Transformations of Intimacy in the Contemporary World*, ed. Mark Padilla et al. (Nashville: Vanderbilt University Press, 2007), which addresses the situation for a generation of Jakarta butches and femmes in their forties, fifties, and sixties.

60. Translations of Indonesian are mine.
61. Wina, "Istilah/Sebutan," 8 (capitalization in the original).
62. Wina, "Istilah/Sebutan," 8–9.
63. Wina, "Istilah/Sebutan," 9.
64. This branch was established after I left West Sumatra in 2001 and comprised several of the individuals who participated in my research, making me one of the vectors in the circulation of queer knowledge.
65. Ann Stoler, "Educating Desire in Colonial Southeast Asia: Foucault, Freud, and Imperial Sexualities," in *Sites of Desires, Economies of Pleasure: Sexualities in Asia and the Pacific*, ed. Lenore Manderson and Margaret Jolly (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1997), 1–26.
66. See Dennis Altman, *Global Sex* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2001); Lenore Manderson and Margaret Jolly, "Sites of Desire/Economies of Pleasure in Asia and the Pacific," in Manderson and Jolly, *Sites of Desires, Economies of Pleasure*, 1–26; Elizabeth Povinelli and George Chauncey, "Thinking Sexuality Transnationally: An Introduction," *GLQ* 5 (1999): 439–49.
67. Martin F. Manalansan IV, *Global Divas: Filipino Gay Men in the Diaspora* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2003), ix. Don Kulick's examination of *travesti* male femininity in Brazil also encourages broadening notions of gendered subjectivities, arguing that in Brazil masculinity and femininity do not arise from male or female bodies (*Travesti: Sex, Gender, and Culture among Brazilian Transgendered Prostitutes* [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998]). See also Megan Sinnott, *Toms and Dees: Transgender Identity and Female Same-Sex Relationships in Thailand* (Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press, 2004); and Gloria Wekker, *The Politics of Passion: Women's Sexual Culture in the Afro-Surinamese Diaspora* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2006).
68. Boellstorff's analysis of *gay* and *lesbi* in Indonesia provides useful ways to think about national gay citizenship, but he frames his subject in a way that obscures the multiplicity of *lesbi* and *gay* subjectivities and the different circuits of queer knowledge in Indonesia. See Boellstorff, *Gay Archipelago*.